



△ MEDIEVAL GRANDEUR

Covering an area of 161,500 square ft (15,000 square m) and ringed by 10-ft- (3-m-) thick walls and numerous towers, the Palais des Papes dominates the town of Avignon.

Palais des Papes

*A grand monument to papal power in the 14th century
and the largest Gothic palace in the world*



In 1309, Pope Clement V abandoned Rome and moved the papal capital to Avignon on the banks of the River Rhône, where it remained until 1377. The vast papal palace was constructed by two popes in less than 20 years, from 1335 to 1352. Pope Benedict XII's Palais Vieux ("Old Palace"), completed in 1342, was built around a central cloister and housed the consistory (papal court), treasury, two chapels, and a cavernous Great Tinel—a reception and banqueting hall, where the cardinals came together to elect a new pope. The whole palace was flanked by several enormous towers. In 1342, Pope Clement VI began enlarging the palace with the addition of the Palais Neuf ("New Palace"), including the Grande Chapelle ("Great Chapel"), Audience Hall, and more towers. The palace deteriorated after the papacy returned to Rome, was sacked by French revolutionary forces in 1789, and was further damaged by military occupation afterward. Restoration began in 1906, and the palace was classified as a World Heritage Site in 1995. The surviving paintings and frescoes reveal the beauty of the original decoration.

PALACE PLAN

This plan shows the main construction phases of the palace, identifying the extents of Benedict XII's Palais Vieux and Clement VI's Palais Neuf. The palace is characterized by the number, thickness, and height of its towers and by its crenellated walls, which made it an impenetrable fortress.

